

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 2
Another Kind of Freedom ~
Perfect Love Casts Out Fear

14 June 2026



"Prades, the Village" (Prades, el poble), 1917
by artist Joan Miró

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

*Organ Prelude Concert in honor of Marco Diaz:
Improvisation on O WALY WALY and HYFRYDOL
Gymnopédie (Erik Satie)
Sabor A Mí (Carillo/Mitchell)
Ballad pour Adeline (Paul de Senneville)
Für Elise (Ludwig van Beethoven)
Allegro Reale (William Walton)*

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Sarah Fuhrmeister

We have gathered together,
turned our hearts to praise,
willed that we might be moved
to live out the wholeness of love
in this broken world.

We have seen the places in this world
where the living of that wholeness is so needed.
Yet we cannot stop there.
We cannot pretend that to gather,
be moved,
notice pain and injustice
is anywhere near enough.

We must push ourselves further –
push to know the completeness
of love in our own lives,
push to recognize what it means,
push to work miracles in its name.

*We say this as those
who long to walk as Jesus
and every other justice-seeking revolutionary
has only ever walked:
to change the world!*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

God, Whose Love is Always Stronger

HYFRYDOL

God whose love is always stronger
Than our weakness, pride and fear,
In your world, we pray and wonder
How to be more faithful here.
Hate too often grows inside us;
Fear rules what the nations do.
So we pray, when life divides us:
Give us love, God!
Make us new!

Love is patient, kind and caring.
Never arrogant or rude,
Never boastful, all things bearing;
Love rejoices in the truth.
When we're caught up in believing
We will never live in peace,
Show us Jesus' way of living;
May our strength in you increase.

May our faith in you be nourished;
May all people hear your call.
May our lives be filled with courage
As we speak your grace for all.
Now emboldened by your Spirit
Who has given us new birth,
Give us love, that we may share it
Till your love renews the earth.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

God of our yesterdays and God of our tomorrows,
we ask that we feel your presence with us now,
O God, of today.

*Help us in these days of summer
to live with confidence and courage.*

Help us in these days to claim our heritage
with hopeful reality.

*Help us to travel light
carrying what is best from the past to the future.*

God of Vision and New Possibilities
open our hearts and minds to the reality of your presence
this morning.

*As we gather our thoughts in this sacred space,
help us know you are with us in this time,
and in all times and places.*

May your unconditional love flow from us to others
and may the coming days
help us to embrace the Spirit of Life, fully.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

NEGRO SPIRITUAL, arr. KEVING MCCHESENEY

"Every Time I Feel The Spirit"

Cathedral Ringers Quartet, Esme Gregoropoulos, Saginaw Rozzo,
Matt Carlson, and Donald Brown, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

-John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

We pause in our busy lives on this day
as we join with others across our globe,
who, like us, yearn for peace;
who, like us, yearn for the day
when all people
live together in harmony and understanding.
We also pause to celebrate the joy of people coming together,
serving one another with common goals and concerns,
helping each other find our way,
sheltering those who need our help,
feeding those hungry for food and love,
and offering our very best for our children
and all the children of our world.

*We pause in these moments to give thanks to God for grace,
and ask for God's peace to be with us
in this time together, as we acknowledge
and honor the Divine in each of us with this greeting.*

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Welcoming New Members

Rev. Lehman

*Dr. Coco Cabrel | Ryan Conroy | Brooke Hair
Jan Kowalski | Stacie O'Brien | Dr. Brandon Young*

Beloved friends, we gather as one, woven together by the threads of love, justice, peace, and hope. Today, we are overjoyed to welcome these new members into our sacred community:
With open hearts and joyful spirits, we welcome you!

Each of you brings your unique story, faith, experience, insights, questions, enthusiasm, and gifts. Already, you are a blessing to all of us.
Together, we will welcome and celebrate your gifts, as we deepen our spiritual journeys, build community, and work for justice.

May you always find this community a place of belonging and acceptance, where you are known and cherished exactly as you are.
We promise to welcome and celebrate the fullness of who you are, and journey with you, celebrating your joys, and accompanying you in your struggles.

In the spirit of Christ's radical welcome, we say:
*Welcome to the table of love. Welcome to the work of peace. Welcome to the church.
You are home.*

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from 1 John, chapter 4*

Sarah Fuhrmeister

This is the witness of the ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

After the silence, you are invited to come forward to bring your written prayers and to light candles to signify the prayers of your hearts and pray for the life of the world.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of Peace and Love, we pause on this day
to remember the world that forged the path
on which we travel,
even as we lean into the hopes
and blank canvases of tomorrow.

Equip us with patience as we view
the landscape of our lives
and continue to dream and plan
this year unfolding before us.
Empower us, O God, with wisdom
as we respond to the challenges
that rise up before us.

Embolden us to speak truth
where distortions litter the way
around us.
Comfort us when we are wearied by the world
and need shelter from its barbs.
Heal us when the wounds we receive limit and hinder us.
Delight with us when there is cause for celebration.
Implant in us a hunger for your justice.
Anchor in us a longing for your love.
Inspire us to spread the colors of your
glorious palette throughout the lives
that intersect with ours.

Temper our anger with discernment,
and redirect our egos away from
self-serving decisions.

And in all things, O God,
ground us in the light and love and peace
that is your being, that we may set forth
into these days with confidence and conviction,
believing in the future that
we are co-creating with you,
and with each other.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

“Love, Light, Joy”
Laude

SAUNDER CHOI

Sermon

Perfect Love Casts Out Fear

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Sarah Fuhrmeister

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

“Arise, Beloved”
Cathedral Choir

ROSEPHANYE POWELL

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Loving Creator of all that is,
you told us that to love you,
our neighbors, and ourselves,
was to live a life of joy.
Created by Love, surrounded by Love,
and made whole by Love,
we are, O God, made in your image.

With this understanding help us
to receive your hope and free us from fear,
as you take our hands and lead us
to love others as you have loved us.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Blessed are you
who bear the light
in unbearable times,
who testify
to its endurance
amid the unendurable,
who bear witness
to its persistence
when everything seems
in shadow
and grief.
Blessed are you
in whom
the light lives,
in whom
the brightness blazes—
your heart

a chapel,
 an altar where
 in the deepest night
 can be seen
 the fire that
 shines forth in you...
 in unaccountable faith,
 in stubborn hope,
 in love that illuminates
 every broken thing it finds.
 May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"O Fortuna/Love Is Love Is Love"
 Cathedral Choir

CARL ORFF/ABBIE BETINIS

*Hymn for the Journey

When Love is Found

O WALY WALY

When love is found and hope comes home,
 Sing and be glad we all are one.
 When love explodes and fills the sky,
 Praise God, and share our Maker's joy.

When love has flowered in trust and care,
 Build both each now, that love may dare
 To reach beyond earth's warmth and light,
 To serve and strive for truth and right.

Praise God for love, praise God for life,
 In age and youth, in calm or strife.
 Lift up your hearts! Let love be fed
 Through death and life in broken bread.

-lyrics by Brian Wren/lf

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

O Fortuna from *Carmina Burana* (Carl Orff)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"I'm happy that we have the opportunity to celebrate Marco Diaz's leadership on a Sunday dedicated to love's power. Marco embodies dedication and love for the work he does and the people he works with. He is genuine, gentle, and caring. Marco's presence, and the energy that the people he leads share, creates the essential space into which all of us are able work more completely. I was a little curious when I heard that one of his favorite songs is "O Fortuna" from "Carmina Burana." I resonate with the power that Orff infuses into this opening movement of his stirring work. The piece focuses on how fate influences our lives, and can get dark at times. There's a poetic, even loving, aspect to the fatalistic philosophical idea that everything we do has been decided. As Orff rolls it out, fate is less a dictatorial menace, and more of a perceived inevitability. In the opening chords, we feel fate's power. We have the option to release into the force of a life whose vastness outpaces any attempt to understand it, or to fight against that which we will never be able to fully perceive. Perhaps love rests in this place of unknowing. And so, we have coupled the opening bars of "O Fortuna" with Abbie Betinis' "Love Is Love Is Love." Betinis quotes several well-known tunes including the Beatles "Love, Love, Love," Pachelbel's "Canon

in D,” and the Gregorian chant “Ubi Caritas” which translates “where charity and love are, God is there.” Through these quotations presented in canon she widens the lens of our understanding, bringing threads of experience into the space to swirl around us. We get lost in the vastness of life so that love may fill our consciousness. Rosephanye Powell’s “Arise, Beloved” is set to the second chapter of Song of Solomon. She uses dynamic growth as a reference to this same life/love energy. Over and again we are reminded that, in love, we can walk past our fear and begin anew. Saunder Choi’s “Love, Light, Joy,” set to a poem by 19th Century Scottish poet and minister George Matheson, shares ever-shifting, expansive musical gestures. With dynamic tools, like Powell, and with temporal gestures and regular key changes, we are constantly invited to feel the freshness that love brings into each moment. Most human emotions come and go within a moment or two. Love, though, can be a constant reminder of the present. It can act as a regular, habitual force for renewal. Love can become an emotional constant. When I experience the results of loving leadership as demonstrated in people like Marco, I am reminded of this profound gift, and eager to seek it in myself.”

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